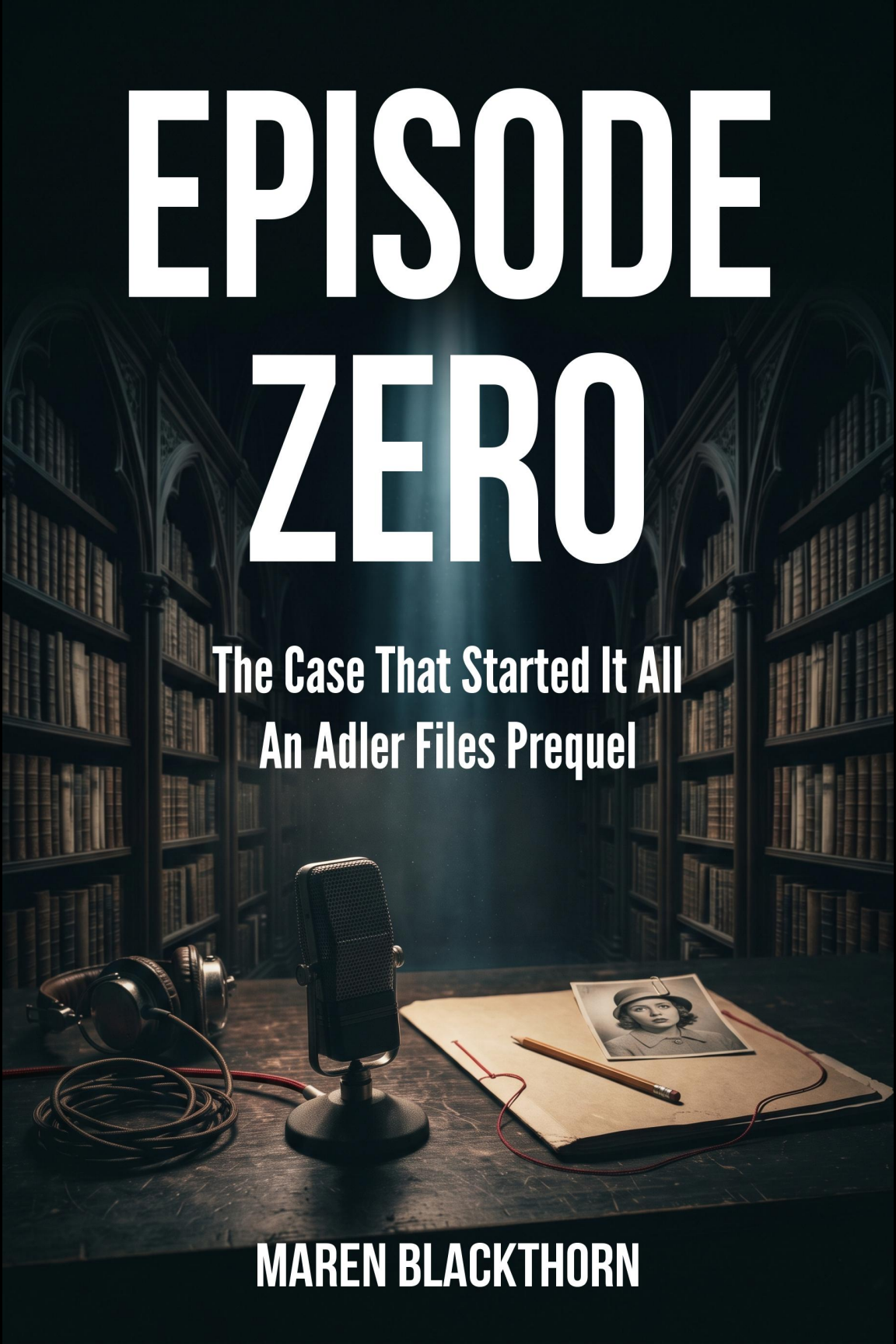


# EPISODE ZERO

The Case That Started It All  
An Adler Files Prequel

A vintage microphone, headphones, a coiled cable, a pencil, and a photograph of a woman in a military-style uniform on a desk in a library.

MAREN BLACKTHORN

# EPISODE ZERO

The Case That Started It All — An  
Adler Files Prequel

Maren Blackthorn

Copyright © 2026 Maren Blackthorn

All rights reserved

The characters and events portrayed in this book are fictitious.  
Any similarity to real persons, living or dead, is coincidental and  
not intended by the author.

No part of this book may be reproduced, or stored in a retrieval  
system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic,  
mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise, without  
express written permission of the publisher.

Published by Obsidian Press

# CONTENTS

Title Page

Copyright

One

Two

Three

Four

Five

Six

Seven

Eight

Nine

Ten

Eleven

Thank You for Reading

# ONE

## *The Girl Who Left*



[Recording — take eleven]

“Here’s what nobody tells you about disappearing.

You think it takes something dramatic. A struggle. A stranger. A van with no plates and a story that ends up on a podcast like this one. But the most efficient way to erase a person isn’t violence. It’s a word. The right word, typed into the right field on the right form, by someone with somewhere else to be.

In Bree Sandlin’s case, the word was voluntary.

Twenty years old. Gone eight years. And for eight of those years the official answer to the question — what happened to her — has been a checkbox. She left. People leave. The file was effectively closed before anyone bothered to open it.

I want to talk about who gets to be looked for. And who gets a checkbox instead.

My name is Quinn Adler. This is — well. We hadn’t named it yet.”



I stopped there because that was as far as I’d gotten.

It was the first thing I ever recorded — the whole of it, a minute and a half of me talking into a headset microphone I’d unplugged from a gaming setup I no longer owned, in a bedroom that doubled as my entire apartment, at an hour when reasonable people were asleep. There was no Focusrite yet. No evidence board, no red thread, no two million downloads, none of the apparatus I’d eventually wrap around this thing until it became the load-bearing wall of my life. There was just me, twenty-one years old, six weeks into a criminology master’s I’d talked my way into mostly so I could keep standing close to the kinds of questions nobody else seemed interested in asking.

Let me back up. Six weeks earlier.

I'd come to Chicago for the program and stayed for the library, which is the most honest sentence I can offer about that fall. The coursework was fine. The seminars were fine. But the university sat on top of forty years of court records and case files and microfiche nobody had digitized, and I had discovered within my first week that a graduate ID got you into rooms an undergraduate could only stand outside of. I spent my evenings in those rooms the way other people spent theirs scrolling — reading cold cases until my eyes burned, one after another, the way you eat chips you don't even like because the bag is open and your hands are bored and somewhere underneath it all is a hunger you've decided not to name.

I knew what the hunger was. I just wasn't going to say it out loud, least of all to myself at one in the morning.

My sister had been dead a few years by then. Long enough that people had stopped lowering their voices when she came up, not long enough that I had. I won't do the whole thing here — that's not what this chapter is. I'll only say that when you've watched a file close on someone you love before anyone thought to ask the obvious questions, you develop a sensitivity. An allergy, almost. You start to flinch at the administrative shrug. The closed box. The word that gets used to make a person stop being a problem.

Which is how I found Bree Sandlin. By accident, the way you find most of the things that change your life.

I'd been chasing something else entirely — a 2011 case out of Rogers Park, a name I'd pulled from a footnote — and the database had coughed up a cluster of adjacent records the way those old systems did, throwing six things at you when you'd asked for one. Most of it was noise. One of them wasn't.

A missing-persons entry, eight years stale. A girl, twenty, last seen leaving her shift at a café on the North Side. And beside her name, in the field where the system recorded what had become of the people it was supposed to keep track of, a single classification, entered by a detective whose name I would come to know better than I wanted to.

Voluntary.

I read it three times. Then I started reading everything.

## TWO

### *The Itch*



There's a thing that happens when a case gets its hooks in you, and I'd learned by then to recognize the first symptom: I stopped being able to read anything else.

For three nights after I found Bree Sandlin's name, I sat down to do the work I was actually supposed to be doing — the Rogers Park case, the seminar reading, the annotated bibliography due in a week that I had not begun — and instead found myself back inside that one stale missing-persons entry, reading the same dozen lines like they might rearrange themselves if I stared long enough. They never did. That was sort of the point. There was almost nothing there to rearrange.

That's what I want you to understand about how these things actually disappear. It isn't a dramatic erasure. It's an absence of ink. The file on Bree Sandlin, twenty years old, last seen the night of March 9, was four pages long, and three of those pages were form. The narrative section — the part where a human being was supposed to have written down what they thought had happened to another human being — was two paragraphs. She had a difficult home life. She had talked, per an unnamed source, about "getting out of the city." She was an adult. The detective had made some calls, found no signs of foul play, and reclassified her as a voluntary departure within, as far as I could reconstruct it, about a week.

A week. I knew what a week meant. I had a private, ungenerous expertise in how fast the people whose job it is to ask questions can decide they're finished asking them.

I won't pretend that wasn't part of it. My sister was a few years gone by then, and I had spent a meaningful portion of those years learning the exact texture of an investigation that ends before it starts — the specific weather of it, the way the language goes soft and procedural right at the moment it should get hard. I recognized that weather in Bree's file the way you recognize a smell from a house

you used to live in. I didn't go looking for it. It just kept being there, in the rooms I walked into.

So I did what I do. I started building her back.

I am, for better and frequently worse, a person who cannot leave a partial picture alone. I pulled what I could find — a yearbook photo, a defunct social media account, a three-line write-up in a neighborhood paper that ran two months after she vanished and clearly only because someone had complained. I built a timeline. I made a list of names. I started a document I titled, with the optimism of a person who has not yet learned what she is getting into, SANDLIN — NOTES.

Bree had worked at a café in Lincoln Square, closing shifts mostly. She'd been taking one class at a community college, which is not the behavior of someone planning to vanish, though I knew better than to lean on that — people contained multitudes, and plenty of them enrolled in things they meant to abandon. She'd grown up in foster placements and aged out hard. The “difficult home life” the detective had leaned on was real. It was also, I noticed, doing an enormous amount of work in that file. It was the kind of fact that let a person stop looking and feel responsible while they did it.

And then, on the third night, at the bottom of the neighborhood write-up, I found the sentence that ended any chance I had of sleeping.

The person who had reported Bree missing — who had kept reporting her missing, who had called the district so many times that the article noted it with a faint, awful condescension — was not a parent. Not a boyfriend. Not a roommate.

It was her brother. Theo. He had been twelve.

Girls with difficult home lives sometimes do leave. I knew that. I'd have conceded it to anyone.

But in eight years of reading about people who left, I had never once read about one who left her twelve-year-old brother behind and never called him again.



## THREE

### *Dev Says No*



I made my case to Dev Okafor over bad Thai food, which in retrospect was a tactical error, because Dev did his best thinking when he was unhappy with his meal and I had handed him a reason to be skeptical before I'd said a word.

I'd known Dev for about a year by then. We'd met in an undergraduate methods course he was taking for fun — he was the only person I'd ever encountered who took a research methods elective for fun — and we'd stayed friends mostly because he was the rare human being who could tell me I was wrong in a way that didn't make me want to prove him wrong out of spite. He was finishing a degree in something that kept changing every time I asked, but the constant in all of it was sound. He recorded local bands for nothing. He had opinions about microphones that he could sustain for forty-five minutes. He owned actual equipment, which is to say he owned the one thing I lacked and the temperament I lacked along with it.

Because here is the difference between Dev and me, the one that would matter later more than either of us understood that night: I am a person who runs toward a thing. Dev is a person who asks what's on the other side of it first.

"No," he said.

I hadn't finished.

"You said 'podcast,'" he said, "and I'm saving us both an hour."

"You haven't heard the case."

"I don't need the case. I need to point out, as your friend, that you're a first-semester grad student who hasn't slept since orientation, and you want to start a true-crime show about a real missing person, which is — Quinn. Do you know how many of those exist? It's a genre now. It's people in their cars doing dramatic voices about other people's worst days. It's ad reads for mattresses in between."

"I'm not going to do ad reads for mattresses."

“That’s your objection? Not the part where you have no equipment, no audience, no training, no — and I say this with love — no ability to let a thing go once you’ve picked it up?”

That one landed, and he saw it land, and to his credit he didn’t press it. Dev never pressed the ones that landed. He just let them sit there on the table next to the spring rolls neither of us was going to finish.

He was right about all of it. That’s the part I want to be honest about, because the temptation in telling a story like this is to make the cautious friend into the fool who didn’t see what you saw. Dev saw exactly what he saw. He saw a person with a hole in her where a sister used to be, about to climb down into someone else’s tragedy and call it a project. He’d never met my sister. He’d never even heard me say her name more than twice. But he knew the shape of the thing I was standing too close to, and the no he gave me wasn’t laziness. It was the closest thing to looking out for me that either of us knew how to do back then.

“It’s not about making a show,” I said, which was at least forty percent true.

“Then what’s it about?”

I thought about how to answer that. I thought about the file that was two paragraphs long. I thought about a twelve-year-old calling a district desk so many times that a reporter found it pitiable. I thought about the word voluntary and how administratively peaceful it was, how it let everyone go home.

Instead of answering, I reached into my bag.

I’d found it that afternoon, buried in a stack of transit records I’d requested on a hunch I couldn’t have justified to anyone, including me. I’d photographed it, printed it, circled the line in red because some part of me had already known I’d be sliding it across a table at someone. I put the page down in front of Dev and turned it so he could read it right side up.

“Before you say no again,” I said, “tell me why a girl who left Chicago eight years ago used a transit card on the North Side the morning after she was supposed to be gone.”

Dev looked at the page for a long time. He did not say no again.

## FOUR

### *The Transfer*



“Walk me through it,” Dev said, “like I’m a person who wants to believe you’re wrong.”

This was, I would learn, how Dev said yes. He never announced it. He just changed the kind of questions he was asking — from why are we doing this to how do we know this is real — and you had to be paying attention to catch the moment the door swung open. I was paying attention. I pulled my chair around to his side of the table so we were both looking at the page the same way up.

“Bree’s card,” I said. “Reduced-fare, registered to her name. The detective’s timeline has her leaving the city sometime after her shift on March ninth. ‘Getting out,’ per the source nobody named. That’s the whole theory. She closed the café, she left town, she’s an adult, goodbye.”

“Okay.”

“The card was used at 7:14 the next morning. March tenth. A boarding and a transfer.” I tapped the two lines. “Brown Line at Western, transfer to a bus at Kimball. North side. Inside the city. Twelve hours after she supposedly left it.”

Dev was quiet, reading. He had a way of going still over a piece of information that I’d come to trust more than anything he actually said. “Cards get handed off,” he said finally. “She could’ve given it to somebody. Lost it. Somebody could’ve grabbed it off a counter.”

“She could have.”

“So this doesn’t prove she didn’t leave.”

“No,” I said. “It doesn’t.”

He looked up, a little surprised that I’d conceded it so fast. People expected me to oversell. I’d learned the hard way that you didn’t have to — that the thing was always more persuasive when you handed someone the holes yourself and let them watch you fail to fill them.

“Here’s what it proves,” I said. “It proves nobody checked. This record was sitting in a system anybody could have pulled with a phone call. If the detective who wrote ‘voluntary departure’ had run her card — the most basic thing, the first thing — he’d have seen a transaction inside the city the morning after his own timeline says she was gone. And he’d have had to do one of two things. Either explain it, or stop writing the word ‘voluntary.’ He did neither. Which means he never looked. Which means the official story that this girl chose to disappear is built on a check nobody ran.”

Dev sat back. The Thai food had gone fully cold between us and neither of us cared anymore, which was its own kind of data.

“That’s the part that gets me,” I said, quieter. “Not that we know what happened to her. We don’t. I want to be careful about that, because the second I start pretending I know, I become exactly the person you were warning me about an hour ago. I don’t know if she’s alive. I don’t know if somebody hurt her. I know that the answer everyone’s lived with for eight years is a guess that fell apart the first time anybody bothered to pull a record. And her brother has spent those eight years being told his sister chose to leave him, on the strength of that guess.”

Dev didn’t say anything for a while. Outside, a bus went by — a real one, the Kimball route as it happened, though I only thought of that later and probably made it up.

“If we do this,” he said, and the if was already a lie, we both heard it, “we don’t do the dramatic-voice thing. We don’t do ‘the killer could be watching.’ We don’t turn a real kid’s sister into a season finale.”

“Agreed.”

“And we check everything before it goes anywhere. Everything. You find something at two in the morning, it does not become a fact until I’ve seen it in daylight. I’m serious, Quinn. The whole reason this is worth doing is the part where somebody finally did it right.”

It was the first rule he ever gave me, and I agreed to it instantly and completely, the way you agree to things you have not yet been tested on.

“One episode,” I said, and put out my hand.

He shook it. “One episode.”

Neither of us believed it, but it's the kind of lie you need at the start of a thing — small enough to step over, load-bearing enough to build on.

## FIVE

### *Amateur Hour*



The first time we tried to record, we did it in my apartment, and it sounded like we'd done it inside a tin can being kicked down a stairwell.

This is the part of the origin story that the people who write in to ask how do I start a podcast never want to hear. There is a fantasy version where you have a thing to say and you say it and it comes out the way it sounded in your head. That is not a thing that happens. What happens is that you say your carefully constructed opening line, and then you play it back, and you discover that your apartment has a refrigerator, and the refrigerator has opinions, and that you personally make a small clicking sound every time you start a sentence that you will now be able to hear for the rest of your life.

"Again," Dev said.

He'd brought his own equipment — a single decent microphone, a tangle of cable, headphones that he handed me with the gravity of a man entrusting a stranger with his child. He'd also brought blankets. Four of them. He hung them over the window and draped them across the back of my one chair and made me build a kind of fort around the mic, and when I laughed at it he said, completely serious, "Sound doesn't care if you feel stupid," which is a sentence I have thought about in many contexts since.

"Here's the thing about patience," I said into the mic.

"No," said Dev.

"I haven't said anything yet."

"You said 'here's the thing,' and you did the voice. The voice where you're a documentary. Don't be a documentary. Be a person who knows something and is upset about it."

"Those are the same thing."

"They are extremely not the same thing."

He was right, of course. He was right in the specific, irritating way that meant I'd have to admit it later, after I'd tried it my way and

listened back and heard exactly the hollow thing he was hearing in real time. The voice — the documentary voice, the one I'd arrived already in love with — was a way of standing above the material. It was safer up there. You didn't have to be a person who'd climbed down into a two-paragraph file and gotten angry. You could narrate.

We did the opening eleven times. By take six I wanted to throw the headphones across the room. By take nine I had stopped performing and started just talking, mostly because I was too tired to keep the documentary up, and somewhere in there the thing started to sound less like a show and more like the truth.

"That one," Dev said quietly. "Do that one again, but on purpose."

I couldn't. That's the cruel joke of it — you can't do the accidental thing on purpose, not at first. But I got close, and close was further than I'd have gotten alone in a year, and around two in the morning we had a rough cut of something. Not an episode. A skeleton. Me reading the timeline, Dev's voice cutting in to ask the questions a listener would ask, the two of us figuring out in real time that the show worked best when it was an argument — when he played the part of the person who wanted to believe the easy answer and made me earn my way past him.

That was the discovery. Not the equipment, not the script. Us. The shape of the thing was two people who trusted each other enough to disagree out loud, and I don't think either of us said so that night, because you don't, at the time. You just notice that you don't want to stop.

We played the rough cut back at low volume, the refrigerator humming under it, Dev's blankets still drooping off my furniture like a kid's fort at dawn. It was eleven minutes long. Most of it was bad.

But there was a stretch in the middle — me explaining the transit card, Dev asking couldn't somebody have just taken it, me saying that's the point, nobody checked — where for about ninety seconds it stopped being two students in a fort and became the thing it would eventually be.

Dev pulled off his headphones. He didn't say it's good. He was constitutionally incapable of saying it's good about a first attempt.

What he said was, "Okay. Yeah. There's something here," which from Dev was practically a standing ovation, and we sat in my terrible

apartment at two in the morning and grinned at each other like we'd gotten away with something.

We had not gotten away with anything. We were about to meet Theo.



## SIX

### *Theo*



Theo Sandlin was twenty years old when I met him, which undid me a little before he'd said a word, because it meant the boy who'd called the district desk until a reporter pitied him was now exactly the age his sister had been when she vanished. He had grown up into her absence. He had become the age of the hole.

He agreed to meet us at a coffee shop near the Western stop, which I noticed and didn't mention — that he'd chosen, without seeming to think about it, a place a four-minute walk from where her card had registered that last transfer. People orbit the spots where the people they've lost were last real. I'd done it myself, in a town in upstate New York I had no other reason to visit.

He was wary in the particular way of someone who has been disappointed by official interest before. He'd talked to police. He'd talked, years ago, to a victims' advocate who rotated out of the role before anything came of it. He had, he told us flatly, stopped expecting anyone to call back. So when I'd emailed him — a grad student, of all things, with a friend who recorded sound — he'd almost ignored it, and the only reason he hadn't was a sentence I'd put in the message that I'd agonized over and that turned out to be the right one: We don't think she left.

"Say that again," he said, before we'd even sat down properly. "Out loud. The thing from the email."

"We don't think she left," I said.

Something moved across his face that I want to be careful describing, because it would be easy and cheap to call it hope. It wasn't hope. It was older and more tired than hope. It was the look of a person who has spent eight years being the only one in a room who believes a thing, hearing someone else say it for the first time.

He talked for an hour. About Bree — the real one, not the file. She'd practically raised him through three placements. She made him do his homework at the café counter while she closed. She'd been

saving, in actual cash, in an envelope taped under a drawer, for an apartment where the state couldn't move either of them again. The envelope was still there, he said, when she didn't come home. She had not taken her money. People who choose to leave take their money.

Dev, beside me, had quietly set his phone on the table to record — he'd asked Theo first, twice, in the careful way he asked everyone, and Theo had waved it off like the question itself was a courtesy he wasn't used to. I listened and took almost no notes, which is not like me. I just watched a person describe a sister nobody had been willing to keep looking for, and I felt the thing turn over in me from a case into an obligation, and I did the thing I would spend the next several years learning not to do.

I promised him.

Not in those words. I was too practiced for that even then. But I leaned across the table and I said, "We're going to find out what actually happened to her," and I watched him take it the way it was meant and more, the way a person takes a sentence they've waited eight years to hear, and I knew — even as it left my mouth, some clear cold part of me knew — that I had no business promising an outcome. I could promise effort. I could promise that we'd look. I could not promise the thing I'd just promised, because the truth might be unreachable, or unbearable, and either way it wasn't mine to guarantee.

Dev caught my eye over the table. He didn't say anything. He didn't have to. We'd talk about it later, in the careful way we talked about the things I'd done that he'd have done differently, and he'd be right, and I'd already know he was right, and I'd have done it again anyway. That was the flaw, in its first small daylight version. It would get less small.

When we stood to go, Theo said, "Wait," and bent down to the chair beside him, and lifted onto the table a banker's box, soft at the corners from being moved between apartments more times than a box should be.

"Her things," he said. "What I could keep. I've had it ready for years." He pushed it toward me. "In case anyone ever asked."

## SEVEN

### *One Step Too Far*



The box gave me a name, and the name was where I went wrong.

It was in a notebook of Bree's — a cheap spiral thing, half shopping lists and half the small administrative debris of a life lived close to the line. Near the back, a phone number with two letters beside it, and on a different page the same two letters again next to the word schedule. It took me one evening to match the initials to a person: Renata Vargas, who had managed the café in Lincoln Square the year Bree disappeared and who, I became increasingly convinced, was the unnamed source in the file — the one who'd told a detective that Bree had talked about "getting out of the city." The sentence that had launched the whole voluntary theory. The sentence I'd come to resent.

I found her in a morning. She still lived in the neighborhood. And I made a decision I dressed up, at the time, as initiative.

I didn't call Dev. That's the part I have to say plainly, because the version where I forgot is more flattering and less true. I didn't call Dev because I knew exactly what Dev would say, and I didn't want to hear it, and wanting not to hear a thing is usually a reliable sign that you already know it. I told myself I was just going to knock on a door and ask a few questions. I told myself a lot of things on the walk over.

Renata Vargas opened the door partway, saw a stranger with a folder, and the temperature dropped before I'd finished my sentence. I'd like to tell you I was gentle. I'd like to tell you I led with the truth — that I was looking into Bree, that I thought she'd been failed, that I needed help. Instead some prosecutorial reflex I didn't know I had took the wheel, and what came out was closer to you told the police she wanted to leave, and I want to know why you said that, which is not a question. It's an accusation wearing a question's coat.

She heard it as one. Of course she did. Her face closed like the file had closed. She said she'd already talked to police years ago, she said she didn't know who I thought I was, she said the word lawyer

— not as a threat exactly, more as a wall — and she shut the door, and I stood on a stranger's stoop in Lincoln Square having accomplished the single worst thing I could have accomplished, which was to teach the one living person who might actually know something that talking about Bree Sandlin got you ambushed.

I called Dev from the corner. I told him because I couldn't not tell him; the rule was already in me even when I broke it. He was quiet for a long time. I'd expected anger. Anger would have been easier.

"Did you record it?" he asked.

"No."

"Good. Because if you had, I'd have made you delete it." A breath. "Quinn. Walk me through what you were going to gain by doing that without me."

I didn't have an answer that survived being said out loud. I'd gotten there first because getting there first felt like control, and control felt like the opposite of how I'd felt at seventeen, standing outside another set of doors that closed in forty-eight hours. I didn't say that part. But I think he heard the shape of it in the silence, because his voice changed.

"Here's the rule," he said, "and it's not the production rule, it's the bigger one. These are real people. Renata, Theo, all of them. They were here before we showed up and they'll be here after we're bored, and the single fastest way to hurt the exact person we're supposed to be helping is to come in hot, alone, with a theory you're in love with. We verify before we accuse. We protect before we publish. If we can't do it that way, we don't do it. I mean that. I'll walk."

It's the only time in our whole partnership he ever said I'll walk and meant it as a line in the ground rather than a slammed door, and maybe that's why it held. I stood on the corner with the phone hot against my ear and the morning going on around me like nothing had happened, and I said the truest thing I had.

"You're right. I'm sorry. I won't do it like that again."

I believed it when I said it. I want that on the record too. I have always believed it when I said it.

## EIGHT

### *The Witness*



We went back to Renata Vargas the right way, which is to say Dev went and I stayed in the car.

This was his idea and it was a good one and it cost me something to agree to it. He wrote her a letter first — an actual letter, on paper, because he said a letter can be read twice and a knock can only be answered once. He said who we were. He said we were sorry for how the first visit had gone, that the person who'd come to her door had been out of line, that we weren't police and weren't writing anything she didn't agree to, and that if she never wanted to hear from us again we'd respect it. He left his number. Then he waited, which is the part I am bad at and he is good at, and four days later she called him.

She wanted to meet somewhere that wasn't her home, which I understood. They met at the café — not the one she'd managed, a different one, but close, in the gravitational field of the thing she'd been carrying. Dev brought his recorder and didn't take it out. He told me afterward he left it in the bag for the first hour, because the recorder was for us and the first hour had to be for her.

Here is what she had carried for eight years.

The night Bree didn't come home, Renata had closed with her. They'd locked up together a little after eleven. And in the alley behind the café, while Renata was dragging out the trash, she'd seen Bree talking to a man by a car — not a stranger, Renata thought, because Bree wasn't standing like you stand with a stranger. There'd been a voice raised, then not. Renata had called out, was everything okay, and Bree had turned and said she was fine, go home, I'll text you — the ordinary sentence that ends a thousand nights and ended this one. Renata went home. Bree never texted. And by the time anyone official came asking, Renata had a head full of fear that had nothing to do with Bree and everything to do with her own life — a immigration status that was not settled, a certainty, learned the hard

way, that talking to authorities was how people like her lost everything.

So when the detective asked his two questions and offered her an easy exit — did she ever talk about leaving, getting out — Renata took it. She said yes. Bree used to talk about getting out of the city. It was even true; Bree talked about getting out the way everyone in a hard place talks about getting out. Renata gave him the sentence he wanted and he wrote down voluntary and the door closed, and Renata went home and was safe and was never, not for one single day since, free.

“I told myself she really did leave,” she said to Dev, on the tape, in a voice I have listened to more times than is healthy. “For years I told myself that. Because the other thing I saw — the man, the car — if I said that, and I was wrong, I ruined someone. And if I said that, and I was right, then I’d gone home. You understand? I’d said go home and I went home.”

That is the thing I keep, out of all of it. Not a clue. A confession — though I’d never have called it that then, and I want to be careful with the word, because it would be years before I learned how heavy that word could get. Renata hadn’t hurt anyone. Her crime was that she’d been frightened and had let a frightened answer stand, and had paid for it every day with the one currency that matters, which is the knowledge of what you did and didn’t do.

Dev didn’t push. He let her get all the way to the bottom of it on her own. And when she finally wound down, when the worst of it was out on the table between them, he asked the only question that mattered, gently, the way you’d ask a person at the edge of a high place to step back.

“Would you be willing to say some of that again,” he said, “with the recorder on? Only what you want. You can stop anytime. Nobody hears it until you’ve heard it first.”

Renata looked at his bag for a long moment. Eight years of going home sat in her face.

“Turn it on,” she said.

## NINE

### *The Small Win*



I want to be honest about the size of what we did, because the temptation in a story like this is to inflate it, and inflation is its own kind of lie.

We did not find Bree Sandlin. We did not find the man by the car. We did not learn what happened in the alley behind the café after Renata went home, and I have to tell you that we still don't know, that there is no version of this chapter where I pull back a curtain and give you the ending you've been trained to expect. Real cold cases mostly don't end. They thaw a little, and then you live in the wet.

What we had was this: a transit record that put Bree inside the city after she was supposed to be gone, and a witness who would now say, on the record, that she had seen Bree alive and not alone the last night anyone could place her, and that the "she wanted to leave" line in the file had been a frightened person's shortcut, not a fact. Two things. Both small. Together, enough to make the word voluntary collapse under its own weight.

This time we did it the way Dev had drawn in the ground. We didn't put it on tape and call that justice. We took it to the police first — to a detective in the area's cold-unit, a tired woman named Powell who agreed to twenty minutes and gave us forty because, I think, she could see we'd done the work. I laid it out flat, no theater. Here's the card. Here's a witness willing to give a statement she didn't give before, and here's why she didn't give it, and here is the part where none of you ever ran the card. I'd learned, since Renata's door, to hand someone the holes myself. I told Powell what we didn't have. It made what we did have impossible to wave off.

She didn't promise me anything. People in her chair have learned not to. But a few weeks later she called, and she used a sentence I have never forgotten, because it was so small and it moved a thing that had been stuck for eight years. She said: "We're going to take another look."

Reclassified. From voluntary departure to an open investigation. A death-and-disappearance case with Bree's name on it again, a file that someone was, at last, obligated to keep open. That's all. That's the whole win. No arrest, no name, no closure of the kind that fits in a season finale. Just a girl restored to the status of a person something had happened to, rather than a person who had chosen to vanish.

I told Theo in person. I owed him that, and I wanted it, which are not always the same thing and were that day.

We met at the same coffee shop near the Western stop. I told him about the card and the reclassification, and about Renata — only what she'd agreed I could share, which was that a witness had come forward, that someone had seen his sister that night and was finally willing to say so. I watched it reach him in stages. First the careful nothing of a man braced for disappointment. Then a kind of stillness, as the words got past the brace. Then — and this is the thing I came for, the thing I would chase down darker and darker hallways for years afterward without ever again finding it this clean — his face simply broke open.

Not joy. There was nothing to be joyful about. His sister was still gone and the answer was still missing and might stay missing forever. What broke open in Theo's face was something I can only call relief from a particular loneliness — the loneliness of being the one person in every room for eight years who believed a true thing nobody else would say. He wasn't alone in it anymore. The official world had turned, by one degree, to face the thing he'd always faced. He put his hand over his mouth and he didn't say anything for a while, and Dev, beside me, looked at the table, giving the man his privacy.

I have done a great many things since for a great many worse reasons. But that was the work. That was the whole of it, before it got complicated, before I learned what it could cost and who it could feed. A person believed. A door that had been shut, opened by one degree.

I would spend the rest of my life trying to feel that again.



# TEN

## *Release*



We almost didn't name it, which would have been a problem, because you cannot upload a thing called *Untitled* to the place you upload things.

By then the episode was real — forty minutes, scored low and careful by Dev, Renata's voice in it only where she'd signed off on it being, Theo's blessing secured twice. We'd cut it eleven times. We'd argued about every cut. We had, without quite admitting it to each other, made something we were proud of, which is a dangerous condition for two people who'd agreed this was a one-time thing.

The name came at one in the morning, the hour when all our decisions seem to have been made. We were trying things out loud and hating them. Dev kept pitching nouns. I kept vetoing. And then I said it half as a joke, half as the truth I'd been circling the whole time — that the thing I couldn't stand, the thing that had started all of this, was the ease with which a case got called closed. The administrative peace of it. The lid going on.

"Closed Case," I said. "Because that's the lie. That's the thing we're arguing with. Somebody decided Bree's case was closed. It wasn't. It never was."

Dev was quiet in the way that meant he'd heard the second meaning before I had. Because there was a second one, and he knew my sister was in it even though I'd never told him more than her name. The case that doesn't close. The one you carry. The box turned toward the wall. I'd picked a title that argued with the word in public and confessed to it in private, and I didn't realize I'd done that until I watched Dev decide not to point it out.

"Closed Case," he agreed. "Okay. Yeah."

We uploaded it on a Sunday night. I remember refreshing the page like an idiot, watching a counter that said 0, then 3, then 11. Three of the eleven were probably us. Dev went home. I sat alone in the apartment with the blankets back down off the windows and

watched the number do almost nothing, and felt a thing I did not have a name for yet and would spend years learning to be wary of.

Because here is what nobody warns you about, and what I'd eventually build an entire uneasy philosophy around: the number felt good. Not the work — the work had felt like grief and obligation and the clean hard thing in Theo's face. The number felt like something else. Each tick was a stranger choosing to spend forty minutes inside Bree Sandlin's worst night, and some animal part of me, the part I'd later have to keep on a very short leash, lit up every time it climbed. People were listening. People wanted more of this. And the thing they wanted more of was, when you stripped the production away, somebody's pain, narrated well.

I didn't think that, exactly, that first night. That first night I just felt the warmth and chose not to examine it. But it was already there, the question the whole rest of my life would keep asking: what does it mean that the thing that helps and the thing that feeds are the same thing, played at the same volume.

The first real message came in around two. Not a friend. A stranger, a woman in a city I'd never been to, who wrote that she'd listened twice, that she had a sister too, that she'd never told anyone what she thought had happened to her, and that for some reason a show by two people she'd never heard of made her feel like maybe somebody would believe her if she did.

I read it four times. I felt, in order: moved, useful, and then — underneath, quiet, unwelcome — the small electric pull of being needed by a stranger who'd handed me her worst thing because I'd performed competence with someone else's. I closed the laptop. Then I opened it again and read the message a fifth time, which tells you everything about which of those feelings was going to win.

The counter, when I finally went to bed, said 64.

It would never say a number that small again.

## ELEVEN

### *Tag*



Dev went home around three. He had a real life to be tired for in the morning, and he stopped at the door the way he always would, after everything, for years, and said, “Don’t stay up reading about it. The number’s still going to be there.” He knew me. He was already wrong, and he knew that too, and he went home anyway, because you cannot carry a person who has decided to sit up alone.

I turned off the overhead light. The apartment went to the blue of the laptop and the orange of the streetlamp through a window I hadn’t bothered to re-cover, and in that half-dark the place looked less like a home and more like what it was becoming — a room organized entirely around other people’s unfinished business.

There was one folder I didn’t open.

It lived on the desktop where it had lived since I’d built it, a plain folder with a plain name, and I did the thing I did most nights, which was to let the cursor drift toward it and then away, the way your tongue finds a sore tooth and then leaves it. I knew what was in it. A coroner’s finding that took less time than a long weekend. A roofline. A town in upstate New York with a mayor I could draw from memory. The careful, procedural sentences that had gone soft at the exact moment they should have gone hard, and a question I had been failing to ask since I was seventeen because I did not yet know how to survive the asking.

I had just spent six weeks proving, on someone else’s behalf, that a closed case is only ever a decision somebody made. That the word was a guess in a costume. That you could walk up to it and pull the costume off if you were willing to do the work and risk the people and not look away.

I knew exactly what that meant for the folder on my desktop.

I didn’t open it. Not that night. I want to be honest about that, because it would be a tidier ending if I told you I did — if the origin of the whole thing was me finally turning toward my sister. It wasn’t.

I wasn't ready, and I knew the difference, then, between not ready and not willing, even if I'd spend years pretending I didn't.

What I did instead was the thing that should frighten you a little, if you've been paying attention.

I opened a new document. I titled it the way I titled everything at the start, before I knew what it would become.

And I started looking for the next one.

## THANK YOU FOR READING

You just watched a podcast get born. What you didn't watch — what Quinn herself couldn't have known, sitting alone in that apartment at three in the morning — is what it would cost her.

Two and a half years after the night this story ends, Quinn Adler walks into the old stacks of a university library and finds a murder confession penciled into the margin of a book. Then another. Then one written in a different hand — describing a crime that hasn't happened yet.

*That's where it all goes wrong.*

### Marginalia

Book One of The Adler Files



Scan the code or visit

**[www.marenblackthorn.com](http://www.marenblackthorn.com)**

*for Marginalia, the rest of the series, and what comes next.*

— Maren Blackthorn